



The Household Water Plan

How much water to store, how to store it, and how to make water safe when the tap isn't. Everything here follows CDC and Ready.gov guidance.

1 gallon

per person, per day, for drinking and basic hygiene. Store more for children, nursing mothers, sick people, hot climates and pets.

2 weeks

is the goal for home. Keep at least 3 days ready to take with you if you have to leave.

Work out your number

Household	3 days	2 weeks
1 person	3 gal	14 gal
2 people	6 gal	28 gal
4 people	12 gal	56 gal
Each pet (approx.)	Ask your vet; add it on top	

Store it right

- ☐ Store-bought water: keep it sealed in its original container and watch the expiration date.
- ☐ Filling your own: use food-grade containers made for water. Don't reuse milk or juice jugs.
- ☐ Label each container with the date. Replace water you bottled yourself every 6 months.
- ☐ Keep it in a cool, dark place, away from gasoline, pesticides and other chemicals.



Making water safe

If your utility issues a boil-water notice, or you're unsure about your water, treat it before drinking, cooking, brushing teeth or making ice.

1. Boil (best option)

- If the water is cloudy, let it settle or filter it through a clean cloth or coffee filter first.
- Bring it to a **rolling boil for 1 minute**. Above 6,500 feet, boil for 3 minutes.
- Let it cool, then store it in clean, covered containers.

2. Disinfect with bleach

- Use **unscented** household bleach with 6% or 8.25% sodium hypochlorite.
- Per gallon: **8 drops of 6%** or **6 drops of 8.25%**. Double it if the water is cloudy or very cold.
- Stir and wait 30 minutes. It should smell faintly of chlorine.

About filters: many portable filters remove bacteria and parasites but **not viruses**. If you use a filter, pair it with boiling or disinfection unless the filter is certified for viruses. Filters don't remove chemicals unless they're rated for them.

Your readiness checklist

- ☐ My household number: _____ gallons for 2 weeks.
- ☐ Containers are food-grade, sealed, labeled and dated.
- ☐ Unscented 6% or 8.25% bleach and a clean dropper are stored with the water.
- ☐ A pot and a way to boil without grid power (camp stove, used outdoors only).
- ☐ I know where my home's water shut-off valve is.
- ☐ Calendar reminder set to rotate stored water in 6 months.

Members share their setups and questions in the Off-Grid Water Vault community. Some gear we mention uses affiliate links: we may earn a commission at no cost to you, and we always say so.